

Damage Control

MUCH HAS BEEN SAID ABOUT INTEL'S

10NM PROCESS NODE. We were supposed to have them way back in 2017 but the Canon Lake CPUs were practically nonexistent. The mainstream lines have all been using some iteration of the 14nm process which has gone through many 'pluses' since it was introduced for the first time. Despite the lack of any actual mass-market product, Intel has been sticking to their guns about 10nm being on track. We first saw the 14nm silicon with Broadwell and that was a little over five years ago. The shift to 10nm was supposed to have happened two years ago but now we've started hearing rumours about the upcoming 10th Gen Comet Lake to follow up with the same 14nm node. If five years of running on the same node wasn't enough to iron out all the kinks and get their yields up, we wonder how much time 10nm would take to mature and enter the consumer market in large volumes.

Having to work on 14nm and 10nm has been adversely affecting Intel's output. Both 8th and 9th Gen desktop processors were ridiculously hard to get one's hands on even months after launch. So much so that some of the board manufacturers we spoke to were planning for contingencies and seeking new markets to keep their bottom line stable. All this while, they've never publicly said much about their supply issues until this month when they finally admitted that there was a problem and that they were partnering with Samsung to ease supply of their 14nm parts. I can't even give Intel the benefit of the doubt about being upfront. HP and Dell released their forecasts a week later stating that their own sales were being constrained because they weren't getting enough parts from Intel to begin with. Makes one wonder if the timing of the announcement was planned right from the beginning. Well, if it quacks like a duck...

The surprising part is that Intel released their Q3 financial results stating that they'd managed to clock record profits. Clearly, they're making plenty of money as per their own reports but it seems to be more from the Data Centre Group rather than from the consumer segment. The question as to why these supply issues persist continues to be shrouded in mystery.

One the flipside, Intel finally revealed more information about their discrete GPU and it turns out that it's going to be a Data Centre product. After all these months of building hype around Intel Odyssey as a consumer product, Intel's announcement of the Exascale GPU was a bit surprising. Usually, the enterprise GPU and consumer GPUs share the same silicon with just a few minor changes being made. Sometimes, there is literally no difference aside from the name and a paint job on the outside. Perhaps I'm reading too much into it all, but when the news of two of the top marketing executives exiting from the Intel discrete graphics group came to my attention, I couldn't help but wonder if we're going to be seeing a consumer grade GPU from Intel anytime soon.

Sure, AMD has been sticking it to NVIDIA every now and then but a new competitor in the space would be much welcome and everyone was looking at Intel to be that competitor. But when you look at all of the news and announcements from afar, it would seem that Intel's restructuring to focus more on the Data Centre offerings while the consumer side keeps taking the heat. It's certainly good news for AMD which has proven itself with the Ryzen processors for three straight years and seems to be going strong. Let's hope that we see that discrete GPU launch in 2020. If not, it's going to be one boring year. 

As always, remember to write to us about any feedback you may have for this column or the magazine at editor@digit.in.



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